What I Learned From Grizzly Bears

By Jessica Lind

BERNADETTE: *mid-twenties. A biologist with an intense passion for grizzly bears. She is feisty, easily excitable, and a little quirky. She is almost completely oblivious to anything happening around her.*
HUSBAND: *late twenties. He genuinely loves Bernadette.*
TIME: *A muddled present*
A NOTE ABOUT THE PLAY: *Be aware that the events in this play do not occur in real time. With that in mind, please steer clear of overly literal interpretations.*

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INTRODUCTION

ACTOR: *Stillbirth happens more often than we imagine—10 times more often than sudden infant death syndrome, or SIDS, The impact is impossible to measure.*
ACTRESS: *Fathers, and especially mothers —must figure out how to absorb the vast and sudden sadness, to grieve and, in many instances, to reconcile with a God who has shaken their faith to its core.*
ACTOR: *Decades ago, stillborn babies were whisked away from their parents to morgues; doctors and nurses pretended nothing happened, mothers were medicated with Valium, parents suffered their sorrow alone.*
ACTRESS: *It was in the late 1970s and early 1980s that the medical and psychological thinking about stillbirth began to evolve when researchers started studying the impact of a baby's death and parents began telling their stories.*
ACTOR: *From silence and detachment came acknowledgment and remembrance. Today* ***nurses encourage parents to hold the babies.***
ACTRESS: *Molds of hands and feet are created. Locks of hair are collected. And photographs are taken. Not just the clinical snapshots that nurses have been capturing for years, but striking and sensitive portraits.*
TOGETHER: *What I Learned from Grizzly Bears by Jennifer Lind*

Bernadette stands behind a table, engrossed in a map of Alaska. A faint beeping noise can be heard.

BERNADETTE: I'm mostly interested in studying how a grizzly's diet relates to its behavior. You wouldn't believe how much impact changes in the environment have on a grizzly. The salmon population in Alaska, for example, has been dwindling because of dams and runoff in the rivers which is a huge portion of a grizzly's diet in the summer. And if the salmon are gone, the grizzlies get desperate and when they get desperate they get mean and when they get mean ... Well, you just better watch out that's what. I'm planning on moving to Alaska to study them. I've already mapped out my research strategy, invested in equipment. All I have to do really is buy my ticket. I mean, there are people out there just dying to give me money. You wouldn't believe how easy it is to get a research grant. This is America buddy you better believe it. Is this parsley?

HUSBAND: Cilantro.

BERNADETTE: I bet you wouldn't believe I was valedictorian of my university, would you? I was. Summa cum laude with a double major and thirty extra credits. Then it was on to graduate school. I'm telling you I am getting pumped. I'm finally finished with school and I am blazing. Nothing is stopping me from getting on a plane tomorrow. I'm on my way up! I'm standing on the edge of the diving board, ready to jump and all I have to do is-

HUSBAND: Don't stand on that.

BERNADETTE: What?

HUSBAND: You can't stand on that.

BERNADETTE: Oh, right. Sorry. *(She lies down on what is now a table. She's completely oblivious to what's going on around her. The beeping noise is foster now, and more muffled sounding. Husband is feeling her stomach.)* There's something fascinating about communicating with animals in their own language. I'm really looking forward to discovering how grizzlies communicate. Oh I've

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read all the books and all that, but I'm talking about specifics. How does a grizzly sound when she's sad? What do the different pitches and rhythms in their growls mean? What noises do they make when making love? *(Sitting up.)* I'd imagine it's a kind of "uhh uhhh" kind of grunting. You know like -

HUSBAND: Please lie down.

BERNADETTE: Geez you're bossy. Anyway, these are the things I'm looking forward to. *(The beeping is so loud now she's shouting over it.)* I've been applying for all kinds of grants. I have a pretty good chance at getting a research grant through my university. Hey, could you turn that thing down? I can't even hear myself talk. Geez. My research advisor is actually on the board so my chances of getting the grant are really high.

HUSBAND: Congratulations.

BERNADETTE: Well, thanks, but I haven't exactly gotten it yet. But thank you. You're a real sweetie. What did you say your name was?

HUSBAND: It's twins.

BERNADETTE: Twins? What kind of a name is that? *(Mounds o/baby stuff, i.e., diapers, stuffed animals, strollers, etc ... pile up on top other. She is being buried. She continues talking through it all, oblivious to what's happening')* Anyway, they only give it to alumni and I'm really the only one qualified. Well, there's this one other guy but he's all into beetles and I'm sure if it came down to choosing between beetles and grizzlies, they'd choose grizzlies. I'd feel like a real loser if I chose beetles over grizzlies. No offense to beetles or anything, but really when it comes down to it I'm sure they'd much rather be associated with grizzlies. As opposed to beetles. *(Realizing she's buried.)* Wow, it's getting stuffy in here. Is anyone else stuffy? Urn, "Twins," is it? You wanna help me out of here? I have no idea how all

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this stuff got here. Pretty inconvenient though I must say. Hey! I'm buried alive here. A little help please ...

HUSBAND: Don't worry, I'll help you.

BERNADETTE: Great.

HUSBAND: That's what I'm here for, right?

BERNADETTE: I don't know. Is it?

HUSBAND: For better or worse. *(He unburies her.)*

BERNADETTE: Wow. You're a real nice guy. A real good-looker too. *(Seeing his finger.)* Crap, you're married. Figures. Oh well. Do you have a brother?

HUSBAND: No. It's just me.

BERNADETTE: Just my luck. Well? ...

HUSBAND: Well what?

BERNADETTE: Who are you?

HUSBAND: I'm your husband.

BERNADETTE: What are you talking about?

HUSBAND: We're married.

BERNADETTE: That's not possible.

HUSBAND: Check your finger. *(She does. She's wearing a ring.)*

BERNADETTE: Well Happy Birthday, this is news to me.

HUSBAND: Your birthday is in October.

BERNADETTE: How do you know?

HUSBAND: I'm your husband.

BERNADETTE: What else do you know?

HUSBAND: You wear a size eight shoe you wash your hair at night and you hate those little marshmallows that come with instant hot chocolate.

BERNADETTE: What do you do?

HUSBAND: I'm an insurance agent.

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BERNADETTE: *(Singing.)* "Like a good neighbor, State Farm is there."

HUSBAND: I'm with AllState.

BERNADETTE: Super. Do you cook?

HUSBAND: No. You do that.

BERNADETTE: Do you clean?

HUSBAND: You do that too.

BERNADETTE: What do you do around here then? Water the plants?

HUSBAND: I usually sit in that brown recliner and flip channels until I fall asleep Then you wake me up when it's time for bed.

BERNADETTE: Wow. It looks like I've won the husband lottery. You can sleep in that chair for all I care.

HUSBAND: Fine.

BERNADETTE: Fine.

HUSBAND: Fine.

BERNADETTE: Fine. *(Pause)* Was that our first fight?

HUSBAND: No. We have them all the time.

BERNADETTE: What do we fight about?

HUSBAND: Cooking and cleaning.

BERNADETTE: Well, maybe if you'd do it once in a while we wouldn't fight about it. *(Pause.)* Did I make it to Alaska?

HUSBAND: No.

BERNADETTE: Why not?

HUSBAND: You fell in love with me.

BERNADETTE: Why did I do that?

HUSBAND: You thought I looked like Tom Cruise.

BERNADETTE: Do you?

HUSBAND: Nope.

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BERNADETTE: Well that was dumb. Where do we live?

HUSBAND: At the end of a cul-de-sac. In a beige house with a beige garage.

BERNADETTE: Why so much beige?

HUSBAND: Development regulations.

BERNADETTE: I feel dizzy.

HUSBAND: You just had twins.

BERNADETTE: Is that what that was? Huh. I didn't see that one coming.

HUSBAND: You did beautifully. You are beautiful.

BERNADETTE: What are you, trying to get me in the sack again? Geez.

HUSBAND: We have to wait six weeks.

BERNADETTE: Lucky me.

HUSBAND: You have to heal first. There was some tearing of the-

BERNADETTE: Yuck! Alright? Seriously. No need to elaborate.

HUSBAND: *(Pulling out some gum.)* Gum?

BERNADETTE: How can you think of gum at a time like this?

HUSBAND: I don't know. I just thought -

BERNADETTE: You know what? You can take your gum and your recliner and your babies and just shove them. Alright? This is nuts. You make me sick.

HUSBAND: *(Pulling out some Tums.)* Tums?

BERNADETTE: What are you, a Duane Reade or something? What the hell else do you have in there?

HUSBAND: *(Emptying his pockets.)* A toothpick, thirty-two cents, a movie stub from *Must Love Dogs* -

BERNADETTE: Ugh. Don't you ever wash your pants?

HUSBAND: *(Continuing.)* My inhaler, a pacifier, three tropical-flavored Starbursts, and a picture of you and the babies. *(He eats a Starburst.)*

BERNADETTE: Let me see that. *(Looking at picture.)* Is this them?

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HUSBAND: Uh huh.

BERNADETTE: A boy and a girl?

HUSBAND: *(Beaming.)* Yeah.

BERNADETTE: They're cute.

HUSBAND: They have your eyes.

BERNADETTE: And your weird chin. *(He offers her a Starburst.)*

BERNADETTE: No thanks. I hate yellow ones.

HUSBAND: What about red?

BERNADETTE: I'll take a red. *(Their hands touch.)*

HUSBAND: I've missed you.

BERNADETTE: Don't get all sappy on me just because we're sharing a Starburst.

HUSBAND: Will you come home with me?

BERNADETTE: That's crazy. I don't want to think about it.

HUSBAND: Where will you go?

BERNADETTE: Alaska. I'm going to go study the grizzlies. You wouldn't believe what it's like to see one of them up close. I mean, I've never actually seen one up close, except for in a zoo, but I don't really count that because their personalities have been altered by human intervention. Anyway, I'm going to Alaska to study them. I'll be living in a tent for the summer when the bears are in the peak of their activity. Then when they go into hibernation, I'll be compiling all my data.

HUSBAND: What should I do with the babies?

BERNADETTE: I don't know. Give them to someone who wants them. Maybe someone who can't have babies.

HUSBAND: But I love them. I can't just give them away.

BERNADETTE: Well, maybe you should have thought about it before you knocked me up.

HUSBAND: You wanted them.

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BERNADETTE: What? That's impossible. Why would I all of a sudden want a litter of babies? That's ridiculous. Ludicrous! Don't you know me at all? Didn't you just hear what I said? I'm going to Alaska! People don't live in tents with babies while closely observing grizzly bears. It's just not safe.

HUSBAND: I'll go with you. We'll live in an RV.

BERNADETTE: Yeah. Maybe we can live in a van and park it down by the river. No. Absolutely not. You're not in the picture, do you understand? Nowhere in this picture, which I am standing in, alone, by myself, is there room for you and your weird chin and all those babies.

HUSBAND: This comes as quite a shock.

BERNADETTE: Yeah, well ... if you have a heart attack over it at least you're with AllState.

HUSBAND: Won't you miss them?

BERNADETTE: I never wanted them.

HUSBAND: That's not true. You said you were ready for a change. You wanted to make a family. You were excited to start a new life.

BERNADETTE: I said all that?

HUSBAND: You did. And you also said you loved me. You said "Life is perfect with you in it." You said that.

BERNADETTE: Maybe I was doped up on NyQuil.

HUSBAND: You meant it when you said it. Anyway, I don't want you to come home with me if you feel this way. I don't want to invade your personal picture or self-portrait or whatever you call it. Good luck. Good luck with your bears. *(He kisses her on the cheek. She kisses him back. It becomes something compelling.)*

BERNADETTE: You do kinda look like Tom Cruise .

HUSBAND: It's the chin.

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BERNADETTE: So long.

HUSBAND: It's not really so much long as –

BERNADETTE: No, I meant, "So long" as in good-bye.

HUSBAND: Oh. OK. Good-bye Bernadette. I'll miss you.

BERNADETTE: Good-bye. *(He exits. Bernadette addresses the audience.)* You really have to be careful because mother grizzlies will fight to the death for their cubs, ripping the flesh of any animal, no matter how large, if her cubs are threatened. If prematurely separated, her cubs have little to no chance of survival. They usually die either of starvation or in the jaws of a predator. If they do survive, chances are their ability to properly social-ize has been severely disrupted. The mother will often wander aimlessly for days, sometimes even weeks, in search of her lost cubs. She shows outward signs of depression, her shoulders droop, her walk slows, she no longer looms but kind of shuffles along - wandering aimlessly along. She loses her majestic dignity, her confidence, and sometimes even her will to eat. The bond between a mother bear and her cubs is extraordinary. The affection and gentleness she displays with them is one of nature's gorgeous mysteries. *(She looks to where he exited. Lights.)*

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Jessica Lind
Book: The Best 10-Minute Plays for Two Actors 2006
ISBN: 978-1575255637
Publisher: Smith and Kraus
Date (Month/Year): September 2007